PRACTICE MAKES **PERFECT**

SEASONED ACTOR ***GEETANJALI KULKARNI***— WHO REPRISES HER ROLE AS SHANTI MISHRA IN THE FIFTH SEASON OF ***GULLAK***— REFUSES TO BE PIGEONHOLED



To stage lovers, she is known for her delightful work in *Piya Behrupiya*, Atul Kumar's acclaimed musical take on the Bard's *Twelfth Night*. Her performance as Viola in it would lead to the breakthrough role as a lawyer in Chaitanya Tamhane's sublime debut *Court*. For most, though, she is *Gullak*'s Shanti Mishra/'Annu Ki Mummy', the much-loved mother of the web series. This week, viewers couldn't escape Geetanjali Kulkarni on OTT. SonyLIV released season five of the popular slice-of-life family dramedy, *Gullak*, while Kulkarni has a key supporting part in Netflix's *Maa Behen*, the dark comedy that also stars Madhuri Dixit Nene and Tripti Dimri.

OTTs HAVE GIVEN KULKARNI THE WORK SHE HAS LONG MERITED BUT THE SPACE ISN'T AS VIBRANT AS BEFORE, SHE SAYS

One look at Kulkarni's filmography and it is evident how her finest work has come in the indie space. "I am very good at start-ups actually," she says with a smile. But she admits that she was "surprised and upset" that post *Court*, she didn't receive many Hindi or Marathi—her mother tongue—film offers. What she got was recognition, which materialised in auditions. Kulkarni cleverly chose to shun parts that pigeonholed her into being a mother of leads to opt for films on the basis of scripts and directors with distinct work processes.

Talking about her own thespian process, Kulkarni says she relies extensively on "rehearsals and preparation" to get into